

Episode 26: Once Upon a Time... (21) *Saint Seiya* Part 8 – Getting Fired Up in the "Twelve Temples Arc"

The hot summer has finally started to show signs of waning, but man, it's still hot in this final week of August.

When I was a student, I absolutely hated this "final week of August" (laughs). This week marking the end of summer vacation, like the ending of "Sazae-san" or "Sunday Cinema Theatre," felt so melancholy and full of sadness that I couldn't stand it.

Even now as a proper (?) adult, when I hear phrases like "last Sunday of summer vacation" on the news, I get overwhelmed by this feeling that I've left something very important undone, and I get restless no matter what.

You all feel the same way... right? (sweat)

Incidentally, as a proper adult now I thankfully don't have "summer vacation homework," but we in the anime business are in "summer vacation homework" mode every week. We're always scrambling at the very last minute (cries).

Well then.

Let me set aside the theatrical version talk for a bit and discuss TV's *Saint Seiya*.

While making the theatrical version, naturally TV broadcasting continued. Just when we were making "The Heated Battle of the Gods," the TV version moved its setting to the Sanctuary (サンクチュアリ) and entered what's called the "Twelve Temples Arc (十二宮編)."

During theatrical production, I naturally wasn't handling per-episode colour direction for TV, but I continued working on TV main story - creating colouring settings for Gold

Saints (黄金聖闘士/ゴールドセイント) appearing one after another, consulting with directors on special scenes like "techniques," and so on.

Even without specific business, I'd show up in the saridashi (撮出し) room to chat with directors, assistant directors, and progress staff, or help fix retakes that came up during saridashi. Everything was fun. The schedule was tough as always, but it felt like a really good period.

Over a year since broadcast started, *Saint Seiya* had stabilised in various ways. Plus the "Twelve Temples Arc" followed the "How much time is left?" rule (I'm naming it now) - a plot structure of saving Athena (アテナ) within limited time, and this was exciting.

Every episode's B-part would build up excitement, then at the perfect moment - "To be continued!" This "To be continued!" golden cliffhanger was why the story built to overwhelming excitement. And the following episode would try to top even that excitement.

What was depicted rather briefly in the original comics - confrontations and technique descriptions - animation succeeded in creating truly three-dimensional, fast-paced battles with skilful timing through animation-unique drawing, screen effects, and voice actors' deep performances.

Especially "technique" depictions were purely battles of sense. Taking various ideas created through animation and building them through finishing and photography. This was an era when you couldn't test or reshoot endlessly on computer screens like now. While some test painting and finalisation was possible, TV series test shoots were rarely allowed for each episode.

"How do we want to show it, how will it look?" - everyone would think together. Taking ideas and expanding images, working out quite detailed and precise decisions in our heads, then turning them into actual materials. Well, this is still the same now, but in

some ways I feel we thought more back then (bitter laugh). When what was shot and delivered matched our imagination or exceeded it, it was pure pleasure. We experienced this every week, every episode.

And then there were the "voices."

Around this time, I got to observe a dubbing session for the first time in my life. I think it was the episode where Shun (瞬) and Aphrodite (アフロディーテ) were fighting. Man, I just remember being continuously moved. Voice actors giving voices to the screens we'd created. Ah, goosebumps! (laughs) It really felt like breath was being breathed in, flat things becoming three-dimensional. I think the actors were also in their groove during this period.

I looked forward to weekly first screenings, and above all I'd become a huge *Saint Seiya* fan beyond just work. That's what it was.

Watching the "Twelve Temples Arc" again on DVD now - man, it still gets me fired up! (laughs)

And the theatrical *Legend of Crimson Youth* (真紅の少年伝説) battle would unfold in this Sanctuary with its "Twelve Temples."

(07.08.28)